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Karolina Strassmayer

Saxophonist and composer Karolina Strassmayer has made her mark in the jazz world both in the U.S. and in Germany. She performed in the States with the Diva Jazz Orchestra, Chico Hamilton, and Nancy Wilson, and she currently performs with the WDR Big Band in Cologne and leads the band KLARO! with her husband drummer Drori Mondlak.

Karolina was interviewed via Zoom on May 25, 2023 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I am in Central New York State and now I'm talking to someone in Cologne, Germany. Welcome Karolina Strassmayer.

KS: Thank you, Monk. I appreciate it very much.

MR: I'm going to introduce you as a saxophonist and a flute player and an educator and someone who got bit by jazz early on.

KS: Actually not so early. I got bit by music but jazz — I did not come in contact with jazz until I was 16. I grew up in a musical family. My grandfather was a conductor of an amateur orchestra. My mother was a music teacher. So I played folk music and I played classical music on recorder and piano and flute and all that. But jazz did not cross my path until I was, yeah, almost 17. And it was really a series of coincidences.

MR: Yeah you and I actually have something in common.

KS: Tell me.

MR: It would be this person.

KS: Oh yes. Cannonball Adderley — my still to this day is such a hero. Actually I just recently got an invitation to perform with the Zurich Jazz Orchestra, "New Bottle, Old Wine" the Gil Evans album featuring Cannonball Adderley. And I am absolutely thrilled and so honored and mortified at the same time because this is such a seminal recording and such an influential recording and to be asked to not re-create but perform it is quite an honor but also it's scary.

MR: Well I want to give you a little encouragement because I was just listening to one of your videos on your website, "Calling For You" and I could hear him in your sound.

KS: Thank you.

MR: That's a good start.

KS: He's still in there, he's in my heart and just, when I first heard him I had no idea what jazz was. I had no idea which instruments were playing. It was really — I grew up in a very small village in the Austrian Alps and I had to commute to go to high school. And a small group of us kids we had to be at the train station at 5:30 every morning to make it

to our school which was about an hour away. And one morning my friend came with a bag of cassette tapes. I mean we're talking about the 80s right, so we're still dealing with cassette tapes. And her older sister had — she wanted to get rid of some of those tapes and just dumped them on her little sister who was my friend and then she came to the train station in the morning with this bag and she said, "Oh my sister gave me these tapes and I checked it out but it's horrible, I don't know what it is but I don't like it." So she just basically dumped this bag into my lap and I thought okay we're going to be on the train, I have my Walkman with me, why not? So I just grabbed one of the tapes and it said "Miles Davis Kind of Blue." I had no idea who Miles Davis was, I had no idea what "Kind of Blue" was, I just was completely naïve and didn't know anything about that. And I put in the cassette tape, the train started moving, it was still dark outside, it was wintertime, and I pressed play and the first thing I heard it just blew my mind — it just blew me away — I had no idea what I was hearing but I knew that it was such a raw power and energy to it and I knew this is what I have to do. I have to do this. But I didn't even know what instrument it was. So I went with this tape to my grandfather and he listened to it for a few minutes you know because he was a hobby musician and conductor I thought he would be able to tell me what it was. And he listened to it and after a couple of minutes he said, "You know I think this might be jazz." You know? So little by little I found out more and more until eventually I found out what I heard was Julian "Cannonball" Adderley on the alto saxophone. And then basically I sold my Moped and bought a saxophone for it and yep, that was really the trajectory of my life was set at that moment. And I'm grateful for that.

MR: Yeah. Were your parents curious about this bolt of lightening and were they supportive of your chosen path?

KS: They were until I said this is what I want to do for a living. Then they did have their trepidations. They let me go ahead and they became more and more supportive. They were supportive of me playing music always because everybody in the family loved music. But jazz and saxophone — that was quite a stretch for them. But once they realized just how hard this struck me and how badly I really wanted and needed to do this and how much I applied myself then they really got it, they really got that, and then they just let me go ahead and do my thing.

MR: How did you pursue hearing more jazz? Was there record stores in your town? Were there radio stations that you could find that would play it?

KS: Well it's funny that you mention that but you know coming from such a small village there was no record store or anything but in the town where my high school was there was a sort of a, you know you could buy anything from eyeglasses to cameras to — it was sort of a multipurpose store and they also had a little music department. And I guess

there was not much interest in jazz LPs at the time of course, so they wanted to get things sold for like a dollar for an LP, they sold off all the jazz LPs. And I just happened to walk into that store at that time. And I bought everything that had a saxophone on it. And I didn't know, you know I had everything from of course Charlie Parker, Phil Woods, Ornette Coleman, then Grover Washington Jr., Coltrane, but just the most — I listened to — and David Sanborn it was like how can David Sanborn and Phil Woods and Cannonball Adderley and Ornette Coleman, how can these all be jazz? I couldn't reconcile this diversity at first, I thought wow, what is all of this and so slowly — I heard Ornette Coleman playing the violin I thought my God what is he doing, I had no idea you know.

MR: I just was listening to a few minutes of free jazz this morning sort of revving myself up for this interview — not that that's what you necessarily do — but it still — I'm not sure how to take it, even at this point.

KS: Well imagine, you know, a little girl from Austria, 17 years old, listening to that, I didn't know how to take that either but it did speak to me in a very powerful way of self-expression and a yearning and a desire to say something — I felt a certain — before I understood anything technical or theoretical about the music I felt the aliveness and the bristling energy emanating from it. That's what I felt before I knew anything. And then when I became, sort of went into the academic world of course I lost a little bit of contact with that original sort of aliveness and energy that I felt — everything became well how do I do this and what's the right way to play that and how do you play this style and how do you play these changes. It became a little bit removed from that original sort of joy and ease that I played with when I first started. But I reclaimed it. It took me some years but I came back to that.

MR: Was part of that the jazz theory — at that point was this like the late 80s?

KS: No, I went to college in '91 — that's '91 to '95 I studied in Graz in Austria and then I went to New York after that.

MR: Well you're a teacher yourself so you know that you can't just teach a student and say well just play by ear because that's where the soul is really going to come from. So jazz has been codified a great deal by now and I can see how when that starts to overwhelm something has to go and the feelings you were talking about I guess did and then it came back?

KS: Yes. It came back but it was — I had to sort of liberate myself from the academic approach and from the desire to do it right — which of course it's great to have those skills and to learn all of that, but there came a point when I wanted to reconnect with music on a deeper level again, instead of doing it the right way or proper you know.

MR: Yeah you've mentioned in some of the literature I've read about overcoming the desire to be perfect and you know perfect and jazz don't really have the same place on the table it seems.

KS: Absolutely not. Yes but you know when I started out there were very few women and girls in jazz, in the jazz school, and somehow I felt in order to have a place in this music as a girl, as a woman, I felt like I needed — I couldn't allow myself to have mistakes, make mistakes or to not know things. I really felt a very strong pressure to prove myself and I think that leads to the desire to be perfect and to pretend like I know everything and you know I deserve my place here in this music. And as much as it was a motivation to practice and to better myself and to study the music really, really deeply, it also left me playing in a way where yeah, really playing in order to prove myself to the world, to my colleagues, to the jazz scene, you know, and that is not a good place to play music from. That's — I realized I was digging in a lot harder than I actually wanted to and actually not really playing the music that really sort of wanted to come out of me naturally, but rather I'm going to show I can do that too. And that was a long, long process for me to overcome that or let go of that.

MR: When you did this [holds up LP] this is now tempus fugit — this was 24 years ago I think. And I'm wondering if you and your bandmates — did any of them have that same feeling like here's a quintet of women and we need to prove that we are really good at this?

KS: I cannot speak for the others, I certainly did, and we didn't talk about any of this at that time. There was really no, or very, very little awareness of that in the scene. This has really, really changed now. Everything's become a lot more open and people talk about it. But at the time I felt the only way to prove my worth or to — you know it's terrible to talk in those terms but this really was what I felt and I know a lot of other women felt that too was by playing in a certain way that shows yeah, she can do it too, she can play or you can sound like a guy. But as far as the others at the time I don't really know. My hunch is yes but see the fact that we didn't even talk about any of this — amongst women! You know? There was so much unconscious stuff that I didn't understand until much, much later.

MR: Was coming to the United States a foregone conclusion or well if you really want to excel that's the next step for you?

KS: I actually did not see myself going to New York initially. My boyfriend at the time, he was a tenor saxophone player, he talked about going to New York all the time. And then I thought okay, all right, I'll go, I'll go. And then I ended up going to the New School and he changed his mind and he didn't end up going so I went by myself. So this was really — I wouldn't say it was a must or it felt like the only way to become, to better myself

was to go to New York but I'm sure glad that I did because I certainly wouldn't have learned so many of those things that I learned in New York if I hadn't gone there and left my comfort zone and really jumped into the cold pool many, many, many times.

MR: Did you have experiences with jam sessions in some of the small clubs there in New York while you were at the New School?

KS: Yes. I went to jam sessions all the time. It scared the hell out of me but I did it and I'm glad I did because it just — it helped me to develop courage and to also what you were saying before about perfection. When you go to a jam session you never know what's going to happen so that's no way you can be perfect there you can just stay afloat and that's what I tried to do and sometimes I didn't stay afloat. But it's those experiences that have always moved me forward.

MR: Have you had the experience of getting up on stage at those sessions and someone calls a tune and you don't know it?

KS: Yes.

MR: How do you stay afloat?

KS: With good ears and chutzpa.

MR: All right. And why did you — I mean I'm reading here you played of course with Diva and Chico Hamilton and a long list — what made you decide to return not back to Austria but did you go to Germany first when you went back?

KS: It was really, again, a series of coincidences how I came to the saxophone, how I came to New York, and then also how I ended up here in Cologne. I didn't even know about the vacancy in the WDR Big Band. I received an Email from the bassist of the big band John Goldsby who had read something in an American jazz magazine — unfortunately it doesn't exist anymore it was a really great magazine, *Jazz Improv* magazine. You probably remember it. And they had a sample CD. They interviewed artists and I was one of those and each of the people who were interviewed also were featured on that sample CD. And John Goldsby read the interview and heard the track from my — actually my very first CD. And he sent me an Email and said do you want to apply, we have a vacancy in the WDR Big Band. And I thought okay, yes, gladly. And so I actually had no intention of leaving New York. I was really happy there and things were going well and I didn't — in fact I couldn't even imagine leaving New York but joining the WDR Big Band was really such a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity that I just felt like I had to do it and I did it and I'm glad. Even though I miss New York sometimes, I have no regrets about leaving New York and joining the band here in Cologne. But it was not any big plan of mine to return to Europe, it just so happened.

MR: I assume that gig required some doubling and were you prepared for that?

KS: Yes. Yes I was prepared for that. In Diva also we played a lot of doubles and I played a lot of gigs in New York with various big bands. And I realized that doubling is so crucial. You just don't get called for these kind of bands if you don't have your flute and clarinet together. And clarinet is not my favorite instrument but on the flute I feel comfortable so that is definitely my stronger double and in the WDR Big Band even though all of us play all the doubles, each one of us has stronger doubles and things or if you feel more comfortable then we just pass those parts around and I usually end up with the flute and the piccolo parts. And Johan Horlen, who is the lead alto player in the WDR Big band, he is a very strong clarinetist so he's happy to play the clarinet parts. So we worked it out amongst ourselves.

MR: That reminds me of a conversation I just had with a couple of the top lead trumpet players in Los Angeles and they said that, that sometimes — well there's a part here and you know what you'd be a lot better on it so "pass it on" they would say.

KS: Yeah. And that's how we do it in the WDR Big Band too. And most of the writers already know anyway who to write the piccolo part for, or the alto flute part, or the clarinet solo. They know, or they ask. Or even when there are solos, where one of us feels more comfortable in this stylistic environment or not so comfortable in that, then we just pass it around. It's really very easygoing, everything. Because you know when you play music together almost every single day there's no room for ego and for all that stuff because you know next time you're going to be glad if you can pass something on to somebody else or you're glad when somebody throws you something and it creates a very jovial, very respectful and very easy environment that way.

MR: What a thrill to sit down and get a new piece passed out to you by Mike Abene or any of these fantastic writers.

KS: It is absolutely a thrill and it has really been also such an education for me as a musician to be immersed in all these different sounds and every week something different. A couple of weeks ago we just did a program with Vince Mendoza — he arranged Michel LeGrand's music. Next week Bob Minter is coming and we're playing a program of funk music and it's — and especially Michael Abene, you mentioned Michael, he is such a hero to me. He's maybe ten years or eleven years that he was our principal conductor. I think he wrote over one thousand arrangements for the band. And to just be right in the middle of that and play these beautiful sounds that he concocts and he has such a hand for writing for doubles and for all the different sounds. You know he uses euphoniums and flugels and tuba and of course in the woodwinds I mean sometimes we have to switch instruments like fifteen times in one arrangement you know it's like just going back and forth. But he's not just doing this to torture us, he really gets beautiful nuances and colors

out of a big band. And my ears have really, really opened up because I have had the opportunity to play all this different stuff. It's a real privilege.

MR: Is the ensemble supported by the State — national funding, that kind of thing.

KS: Yes. All the public broadcasting in Germany is supported by a broadcast tax that every citizen pays or every household pays. So we are in the State of North Rhine-Westphalia and the citizens of North Rhine-Westphalia support the West German radio, which is Westdeutscher Rundfunk West German radio, that's what we're called. So yes, they make it possible.

MR: Nice. I wish we would learn from that.

KS: Yes it really is amazing the system and the appreciation that it creates here for this music and I think often about how much music we have played over the years that would have never — wouldn't exist if it weren't for this because this music is always or almost always commissioned for the band. So this music wouldn't exist if somebody here in the West German radio wouldn't take money and say to Vince Mendoza or to Michael Abene or to Bob Mintzer or to Jim McNeely or whoever, say please write a program of Michel LeGrand's music arranged for the big band with this and that soloist and being part of this creation is quite something.

MR: Was there a media announcement about the first girl in the WDR big band?

KS: Yes. It was quite a big — I don't want to say uproar — but there was a lot of media interest because none of the German radio or European radio big band had a female member at the time. This was 2004 when I joined. And yes, it was kind of strange. It was a little bit similar to I don't know if you remember that in the 90s I think it was when the Vienna Philharmonic began accepting women because they were pressured. There were even articles in the *New York Times* and it was, in the WDR this was not the case, it just so happened that I joined. And the decision was made by all the band members. This was not a decision — this is how we fill all the positions. It's really a vote of all the band members. It's not a decision of the management or of the broadcast company or anything like that. But it was kind of strange for me at first because there was all this interest, also womens' magazines and newspapers, and they all just wanted to know what is it like to be the only woman in the WDR Big Band. And nobody asked me about my musical background you know they all just wanted to know are they nice to you or are you allowed to play solos? Do they make jokes or do they grope you? It was quite sensationalist, depending on the publications. And of course that died down after a while and it became normal and all of that. But I really began to really loathe that question, like oh what is it like to be the only woman and I really never wanted to deal with that because I thought please just let me play music. I am a person who plays music. But I realized over time that it is something unusual, it is something that interests people

because they see it, they see a band of eighteen people and one woman in there and they want to know why, they want to know what is it like, and I get it. I really get that. And I've really come to embrace the question and I've also come to embrace the opportunity that I have in this position with this visibility that I have in the WDR Big Band not only through my musical contribution but I've become very outspoken about being a woman in jazz. I've also founded a mentoring program for women at the University that I teach, it's called Folkwang University in Essen, and I give empowerment classes for women. They are at the university but also privately and on line and I go to different universities and organizations and give talks and I've become very active and very outspoken about the issues of gender in jazz, which if you had told me that five years ago I would have said oh please, I don't want to deal with it, I just want to play music. But I've really come to appreciate the opportunity for change — that I can really make a contribution and I find it incredibly rewarding and fulfilling to be able to make a contribution to this change.

MR: You had mentioned unraveling toxic mindset in your literature here. Can you describe what a toxic mindset might be with the women that you converse with?

KS: In my personal journey, what I experienced was of course being, coming from a very conservative background from my country but also from my family, and I see this from a lot of women, especially so of my generation. I'm 52 now. Growing up with certain cultural and social messages that really say as a girl you be nice and you be polite, be quiet, be acquiescent, just listen and see how you can fit in and be pretty and be pleasant and don't rock the boat, don't create any stress, don't make any trouble, be nice and sweet. And I realized being a jazz artist is like the opposite of that. Like how can I be sweet and cute and — I mean I still like to think of myself, I have sweetness, but the other — it's like the full spectrum of the human experience is not there if you're just always trying to like not rock the boat and not make any problems. I realized how can I be an expressive person? How can I embody the spirit of jazz if I'm concerned whether people like me or they think that I'm pretty or they think that I'm nice? You know. So I found, I realized that there's such a contradiction between my socialization as a girl, as a woman, and the music that I play. And you know for instance one thing that many women struggle, including myself, struggle with that — I felt that in order, you know you're on stage and you present yourself I felt like that being good looking is a very important thing for a woman who are trying or aspiring to that. But if you're too good looking, if you dress up too much, you're not taken seriously. It creates this double bind. On one hand you want to be good looking, otherwise you won't even be accepted, but if you're too good looking you're not being taken seriously. So this creates a very, very narrow room for operating between — okay, being attractive so that you can even get in there; but not too attractive because then you're going to be not taken seriously. Or as a

woman for instance I never learned how to communicate clearly and directly to say let's do this, I would like to do that, you know can we do this, no I don't want to do that. I mean it's so simple but this was so difficult for me to learn and I still see that in girls today and also older women are finding that it's so difficult. And these mindsets are very hard to overcome because they are baked into us. They are in every fiber you know. And I'm very interested in how I can help women overcome these things.

MR: Well thank you for that. That was very informative. I want to talk about the music that you play that I've been listening to, especially on your website. The tunes, if I had to describe them to people I can't think of the adjective so I wonder if you have adjectives to describe your music. If someone came up to you at a cocktail party and you said you are a composer and they say, "Well what kind of music do you write?"

KS: I love melodies. I love very simple melodies and I love beautiful harmonies. That's really — and also as an improviser I love melody. And even when I play free music, which I also love, I tend to want to play melody. That's always my guiding light. It doesn't matter what stylistic context even with a big band, I always gravitate towards melody. And I know this is not an adjective and it's not my elevator speech —

MR: But we have melodious — we could use that.

KS: Yeah melodious for sure. Lyrical. And one thing I realized over the years that is really what I really want to do with music is I want to create beauty and beauty obviously is something different to everybody. There's no one definition of beauty. But I think one thing that all ideas of beauty have in common is that they move you in some way. And I see it as my job as a musician to really dig deep and to find those things, those melodies, those little motifs, those harmonic movements that move me. And when I sit by the piano I'll play a chord and then I'll play something on my horn and I'll play around until there's something that grabs me, that just goes like ut — okay — oh wow, okay, oh I like this. And that's really my job I see as a musician to really zone in to hone into that, to say what is it that makes me move forward in my chair and say ah, what is that. Wow, I like that, I like that. So unearthing what it is that I like that makes me feel good, that feels beautiful to me and that's what I want to bring forth. That's what I see as my life's work in music, to create my definition of beauty in the hopes that it moves other people too.

MR: That's sort of what I was going to try to ask, when you're sitting and composing or when you're in the middle of an improvisation are you aware of the audience? Maybe I could say are you playing for the audience or are you playing for yourself?

KS: Both. Maybe I can start by saying when I first started out as a musician I was definitely playing for myself. And I was playing in a way that I wanted to get respect, I wanted to get acknowledged, I wanted to be seen as somebody who can play, so really from a very sort of needy place of like yeah look I can play. But I was playing for myself and over the

years as I've grown as a human being I have discovered that giving with music is a great privilege. It is an experience that we can give people and what I give is actually this — what moves me, my idea of beauty, but also when I'm on stage I'm somebody who is present. I'm present for the music and for the people in that moment. And that's really at the center. It doesn't matter the notes, the style or this or that. It is am I here? Am I really here? Am I really present for this? And that is a gift and it's a gift to myself because I feel really great when I can play from that place of presence and aliveness and I can be relaxed. I can trust the music. I can let the music evolve. I can really delight in what the other musicians are playing and I've seen the reaction of people who come to my concerts over the years. You know the biggest compliment you could give me when I was maybe 25 or 30 — "Yeah man, she can really play, the girl can really play. Do you see how she can really tear it up." You know. That kind of — "Man she was really shredding those rhythm changes" or "she sounds like a guy when you close your eyes." Right? This was just like oh yeah, my ego is like thank you, thank you, thank you. And now the biggest compliment or the most beautiful thing that I can get after a concert or during a concert from people is when I see that they close their eyes and they relax their face and their head just sort of moves back a little bit and to the side and they begin to connect with themselves and the music and the present moment. And when I see that then I know I'm doing it right. And that to me is really, this is what I get back when I look out into the people and there's a certain softness in their face. There's a certain, maybe a slight smile or there's a wonder in their eyes where they just see like wow, they're filled with something pleasant. A pleasant feeling. And by that I don't mean like playing what the people like. I don't mean that. I mean really what I like and I think people can feel from a performer whether that person is really present and is really giving. And then they don't care. Then you can play the out shit and it touches them.

MR: Let's talk about that out a bit. Yesterday I did an interview with Roscoe Mitchell. And I didn't even — it wasn't a question but I said something about free jazz. And he was adamant there's no such thing as free jazz. And I think the reason, well he said it, he says considering how hard I work at this music there's no such thing as free jazz — and he was almost angry about it. For you, what does free actually mean?

KS: Wow. That is a very deep question. Wow. I'm not sure how to answer that. That is such a wide question. Because if I say okay free means we're not playing a tune or we're not playing over a structure, but that's actually not true either because while I'm playing free music in my head I create a structure and I create something. I create, it's just a spontaneous structure that I play off of. I can't answer it, I wish I could. How did he answer it?

MR: I can't answer it either but I've noticed, I'm not necessarily a person who has listened to a great deal of it but going back to "Ascension" and some of the music I listened to that Mr. Mitchell had recorded, that it seemed like, you have to be careful with generalities in music but it seemed like the majority of free jazz for one thing did not have a steady tempo, especially from the drums and bass. In other words we're freeing ourselves from that role that we normally play.

KS: I guess we're freeing ourselves from playing, from doing these things like playing rhythm, playing melody, playing harmony, in that certain way but we still use time, we still use rhythm and melody and harmony but just not in a preconceived way I guess. But when I play free music I always tend, I gravitate toward certain things. My ear just takes me there. I just, to me, when I play free music then I begin to knit, if you will, a series of changes that I don't share with the others. They follow or they don't follow but I still — my ear still wants to go to some things that I recognize. So it's — to define what free music is I wouldn't dare.

MR: Well Karl Berger surprised me when he said that playing free music is much more precise than not, than non-free he says. "I make my own parameters and it's not free like people think — play whatever you want." He was very adamant about the fact that this takes much more concentration than you would think and there are guidelines but they're self-imposed.

KS: That's a nice way to say it. There are guidelines and they are self-imposed and people just don't know what the guideline is going to be at that moment, that they're shifting guidelines maybe and you don't agree on them necessarily. Everybody can have their own or you go with the other person's guideline or — it's — I've played quite a lot of free music with David Friedman and Drori Mondiak, my husband, on drums. David Friedman on vibraphone. And we did a whole CD and we never said one word about the music but when you listen to the CD it's not that obvious that it's free music because I guess it's maybe we all gravitate towards tonal centers and playing over a rhythm or something like that so we still want to have some things that are orderly.

MR: Well if you — do you remember how many tunes were on that recording you just mentioned of free music?

KS: Maybe nine or ten?

MR: Okay so if there's nine or ten how do you get started so that this one is different than the last one? Does someone suggest something at least? Tempo, a feeling?

KS: Yes. That's usually how it starts, that somebody starts with an idea, the drums start with a rhythm or David starts with a color and then for instance on one piece we were just playing with two or three intervals and that is what happened. Or in another piece we focused more on the rhythmic motif. Or on one other piece maybe we stayed largely in

one tonal center but everything else shifts, the time, and the rhythms you know. So there seems to be like one thing that we agree on and then the rest is pretty open. So it's not like okay playing anything, whatever anybody wants at any time.

MR: Do you consciously avoid sort of copying each other? I mean everybody has great ears in the group, right? So if the piano player played something and you said, "I know what that is I'm going to play it too." And then it tends to get a little cute or something.

KS: It's tempting. It's tempting, yeah. It's what my friend Anat Cohen used to call "Neanderthal interaction."

MR: You sounded just like her too.

KS: So yeah that can get a little too cute. So I try not to go there but sometimes it happens and I don't think it's a horrible thing when it happens. You can have a sense of humor about it. I guess when you play free music, or for me actually it's really helping me to relax about music because you've just got to let things go. You can't control what other people play. When I write a tune and I say I want you to play this chord here and there's the altered chord and no don't play that, so you're much more in control of what happens. But with free music I've learned to relax and trust that something is going to happen and it's not going to be what I think will happen or what I want to happen. I had to learn to just go with that instead of thinking ooh I don't like this, oh what are they doing. You've just got to let go of that and just at any given moment just let go, let go and go forward.

MR: It's almost like you change your expectations.

KS: Yes.

MR: What about song titles? I was looking at a couple — now it seemed to me that a couple of the song titles on your videos could be descriptive. There was "Mallets and Air" and you had a mallet player and you were playing the flute. Okay. Now I'm not sure if that was totally on purpose but I remember talking to one person, a New Orleans musician who called themself the last free jazz player — Kidd Jordan. And they were talking about song titles after they had done quote a free album. And one they named "Last of the Chicken Wings" because the chicken wings had all been eaten. And so how do you name things that are spontaneous?

KS: Either by being descriptive like "Mallets and Air" definitely, sure, that's — or another one on this recent CD is like "Drum Roll, Please." And it started with a drum roll. But sometimes I call things, I call tunes for things that just go on in my life. You know for instance a few years ago I did this record "Of Mystery and Beauty" and that's really when I began to think about what we were talking about before, this desire to create beauty. And that I see our jobs as musicians really to be in this mystery and beauty of creation. So this is really a bigger topic in my life then and it has nothing to do with the

song itself it just is something that I think about at that point in my life when I write that song. So that's mostly how my tunes have titles.

MR: We seem to go to great lengths to analyze things and give them meaning when perhaps the music itself is enough.

KS: But that's what we humans do, right? We want to give a bone to our mind, to always like categorize things or analyze things or name them. I guess it's a very human thing but you're right, the music is enough.

MR: I noticed something about your phrasing that I enjoyed. It almost was like a reverse echo. Like you would play a phrase where your tone was like sort of fragile, and then you'd play a similar phrase with a much more robust approach. Now I don't know if you're consciously doing this but I found it quite interesting as opposed to playing something really loud and then repeating it softly. It was like the reverse but obviously dynamics and space are important to you.

KS: Absolutely, yes. And also just I'm curious about the nuances of the instrument really and that I try also to excavate these different sounds within one phrase, like playing a long phrase and having dynamics within that phrase, that it's not just because it's one phrase it's one dynamic, but to really shape phrases. And then I can't say that I consciously think oh now I'm going to do this, this or that, but I do think about infusing the music with nuance and with breath and with different — I guess it's sort of waves. That it's not just — I love bebop. This is the music that I — you know that really drew me to jazz initially. But when I play bebop, which I don't do much anymore these days, but when I do play bebop I miss a little bit sort of the dynamics within that. Or at least how a lot of players play that. So in my music I like to have a little bit more, yeah, sort of waves of dynamics and contrast and the different colors also of my instrument that I can extract.

MR: Are you able to not allow irrelevant thoughts to come into your head while you're playing? That sounded almost like a backward question or something but.

KS: No I understand. I have spent a great deal of time learning how to deal with those thoughts that come up, especially for me in the first ten, fifteen years of playing the thoughts were really just distracting always. Thoughts like oh shouldn't you play a little bit — shouldn't you push more or play more or come on — oh what did you play now. You know sort of those critical thoughts that come in. And I have learned over the years to have a different relationship with these thoughts. I realized that thoughts, they're always going to come up. I can't shut them off. When you play a concert and you play for two hours, you're not going to be able to have no, sort of irrelevant or distracting thoughts. And I've learned also, through meditation and yoga, to sort of let these thoughts come and go and not hang on to them. It's the relationship with the thoughts that has changed. Not that I have thoughts or don't have thoughts. I have thoughts all the time, but

I have learned to not sort of go down the rabbit hole. And I've learned to just hear the thought and just refocus, coming back to the music, like in meditation when you focus on the breath and every time a thought comes I sort of let the thought go and I return to the breath. In the music I try to do the same thing. That's been super helpful for me.

MR: Excellent. A couple of more questions, we've been at it for a while. Do you have female — women students at the university?

KS: I do.

MR: Excellent.

KS: Quite a few. Yes.

MR: Glad to hear that. What — are there one or two things that you really demand that they absorb and are able to do or to know about before they graduate?

KS: Yes. Again, that's a really big question. I want them to be able to speak the language of jazz and that really means, to me, even though if they're not into bebop but I want them to understand that language. And if they can't really, I wish they could all really execute it and all really play it and be fluent in it, and that they are excited about it, but it's at the core of whatever music or improvised music we're going to end up playing but the language of Charlie Parker, to me, is just so central that I really do not let them off the hook. Even when they try, they pull out all the tricks you know, trying to distract me but I really try to get them excited about that. And most of the time I manage to — it doesn't mean they end up being able to play like that but understanding how this language works.

MR: Did your grandfather live long enough to see your success?

KS: No. Unfortunately not. No. I think about that sometimes, yeah.

MR: How about your father, your parents?

KS: My father is still alive. He's actually turning 86 tomorrow and he's still going strong. We actually still go hiking together a lot. My mother, unfortunately she passed away in 2016 but she really has been my musical guide early in my life. She was a music teacher and she was the one who got me started on the recorder and piano lessons and her love for music and for the arts really lives very strongly in me and I'm very thankful for that. And even though both my parents don't understand anything about jazz really but they would come to concerts. And over the years I think they acquired a little bit of a taste for it. But my father is definitely a Beethoven/Mozart/Mahler/Bruckner kind of guy.

MR: I loved the anecdote that you wrote about your father conducting the Vienna Philharmonic with headphones on.

KS: Yeah. That's one of the first memories I have as a kid, seeing my father sort of air conducting the Vienna Philharmonic and you know my father is such a down-to-earth person. He's a retired forest ranger. And to see him, you know like so filled with passion for the music. And he looked like Karajan conducting. That really left a deep, it really

impressed me deeply to see him. I thought wow, this music, if it can move my father like that you know, that's really got to be something very special. Yeah.

MR: Speaking about moving music, I wonder if you've heard Cannonball's live version of "Somewhere."

KS: I think so.

MR: All right. Well I'm going to send it to you because —

KS: Please do.

MR: You know you've been talking about the heart and beauty and that's a good example of it.

KS: I definitely want to hear that.

MR: All right. Well this is really a fascinating conversation, I'm so glad we were able to connect across the pond.

KS: So am I Monk, thank you.

MR: Anything that you'd like to add on a personal level that we haven't talked about?

KS: Just that I'm really happy that I get to spend my life playing music and giving something of myself in that way and that's a real privilege. And the older I get the more aware I've become of that.

MR: All right.

KS: And now my phone is ringing.

MR: Okay.

KS: I'm sorry. I'm not picking it up but I'm sorry for the disturbance.

MR: It could be a gig though, so make sure that you check your answer machine. Thanks for your time.

KS: Thank you, Monk.

MR: I'm just going to pause it here and we'll say good-bye.